

JSS 2 NIGERIAN HISTORY – FIRST TERM

TOPIC 4: MILITARY RULE IN NIGERIA II – COUNTER-COUP AND GOWON'S REGIME

1. The Counter-Coup of July 1966

In July 1966, a counter-coup was carried out mainly by Northern officers. Head of State Aguiyi-Ironsi was killed. After a period of uncertainty, Lieutenant-Colonel (later General) Yakubu Gowon emerged as the new Head of State.

2. Gowon's Regime – Key Features

- Creation of twelve states in May 1967 (to replace the four regions and reduce the fear of domination).
- Attempt to hold the country together amid rising tension between the Federal Government and the Eastern Region under Colonel Odumegwu Ojukwu.
- Outbreak of the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970) after the East declared the Republic of Biafra.
- After the war: policy of “No victor, no vanquished” and programmes of reconstruction.

3. Significance

The July counter-coup changed the leadership of the military government and deepened ethnic mistrust. Gowon's creation of states and his wartime and post-war leadership shaped the next phase of Nigerian history.

4. Summary

The July 1966 counter-coup brought Yakubu Gowon to power. His government created twelve states and led the federation through the Civil War and its immediate aftermath.

End of Topic 4